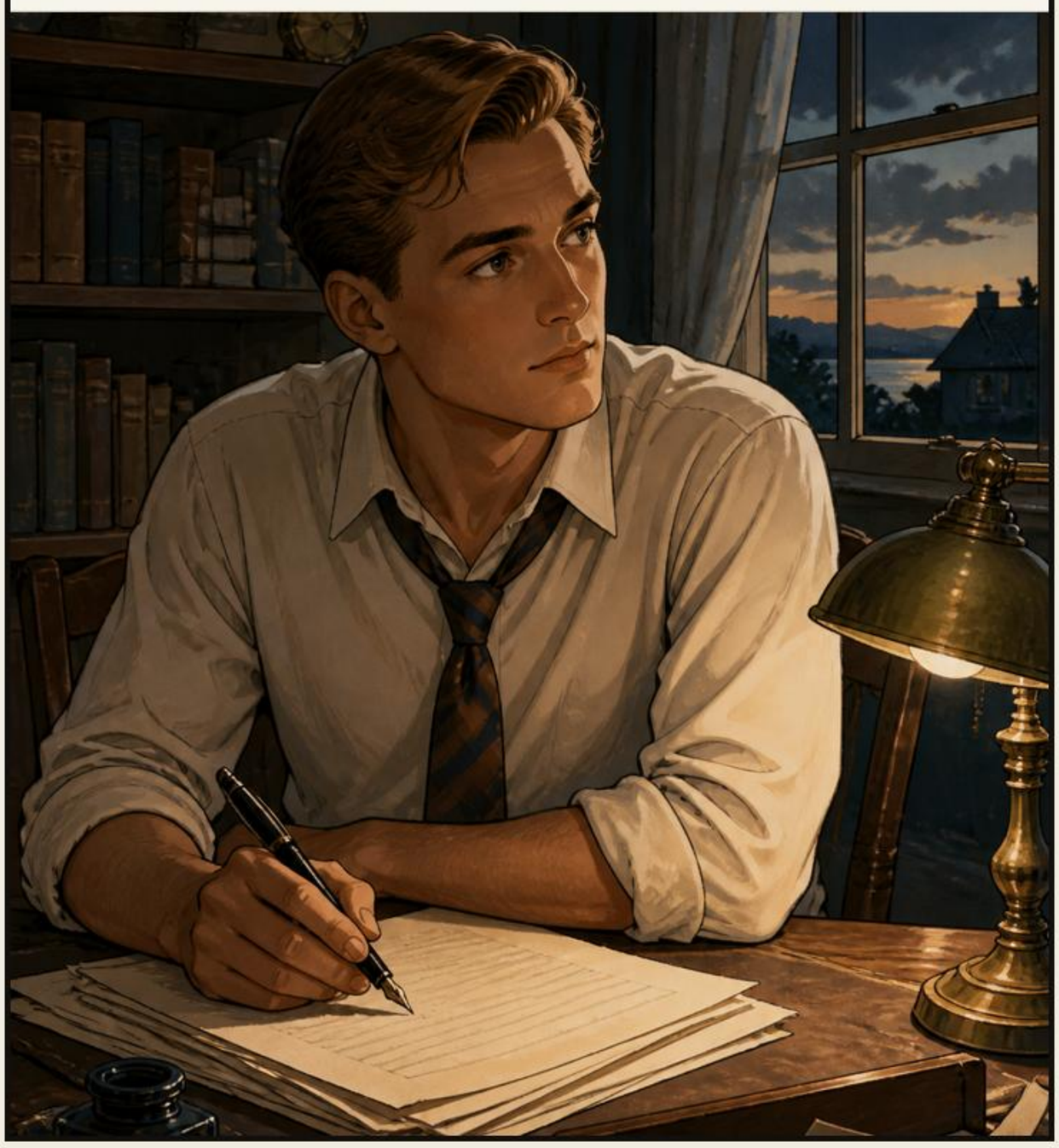
In my younger and more vulnerable years my father gave me some advice that I've been turning over in my mind ever since.



He told me, in the reserved way we'd always shared— My father told me to remember that not everyone had my advantages.



I'm inclined to reserve all judgements—a habit that has opened up many curious natures to me, and in college got me unjustly called a politician, privy to the secret griefs of wild, unknown men.



Reserving judgement is a matter of infinite hope—yet it has a limit. When I came back from the East last autumn I wanted the world in uniform and at moral attention forever.



Gatsby had an extraordinary gift for hope — a romantic readiness I have never found in another man. It was the foul dust that floated in the wake of his dreams that closed out, for a time, my interest in the sorrows of other men.



I enjoyed the counter-raid so thoroughly that I came back restless. The Middle West no longer seemed the warm centre of the world but the ragged edge of the universe, so I decided to go East and learn the bond business.



A young man at the office and I had meant to share a house in a commuting town — a weather-beaten cardboard bungalow at eighty a month. At the last minute the firm sent him to Washington, and I went out to the country alone.



One morning a man more recently arrived than I stopped me on the road and asked, helplessly, how to get to West Egg village. I told him — and as I walked on I was lonely no longer.



There was so much to read, and so much fine health to be pulled out of the young breath-giving air. A dozen volumes on banking and credit stood on my shelf in red and gold, like new money from the mint.





I had been rather literary in college, and now meant to bring all that back, to become again the most limited of specialists — the well-rounded man. Life is much more successfully looked at from a single window.

By chance I had rented a house in one of the strangest communities in North America — that slender riotous island east of New York, where a pair of enormous eggs, identical in contour, jut into the great wet barnyard of Long Island Sound.

I lived at West Egg — the less fashionable of the two, a most superficial tag for a bizarre and not a little sinister contrast. My house sat at the very tip, squeezed between two huge places that rented for twelve or fifteen thousand a season. The one on my right was a factual imitation of some Hôtel de Ville in Normandy — tower, marble pool, forty acres of lawn. It was Gatsby's mansion. Or, since I didn't yet know Mr. Gatsby, a mansion inhabited by a gentleman of that name.



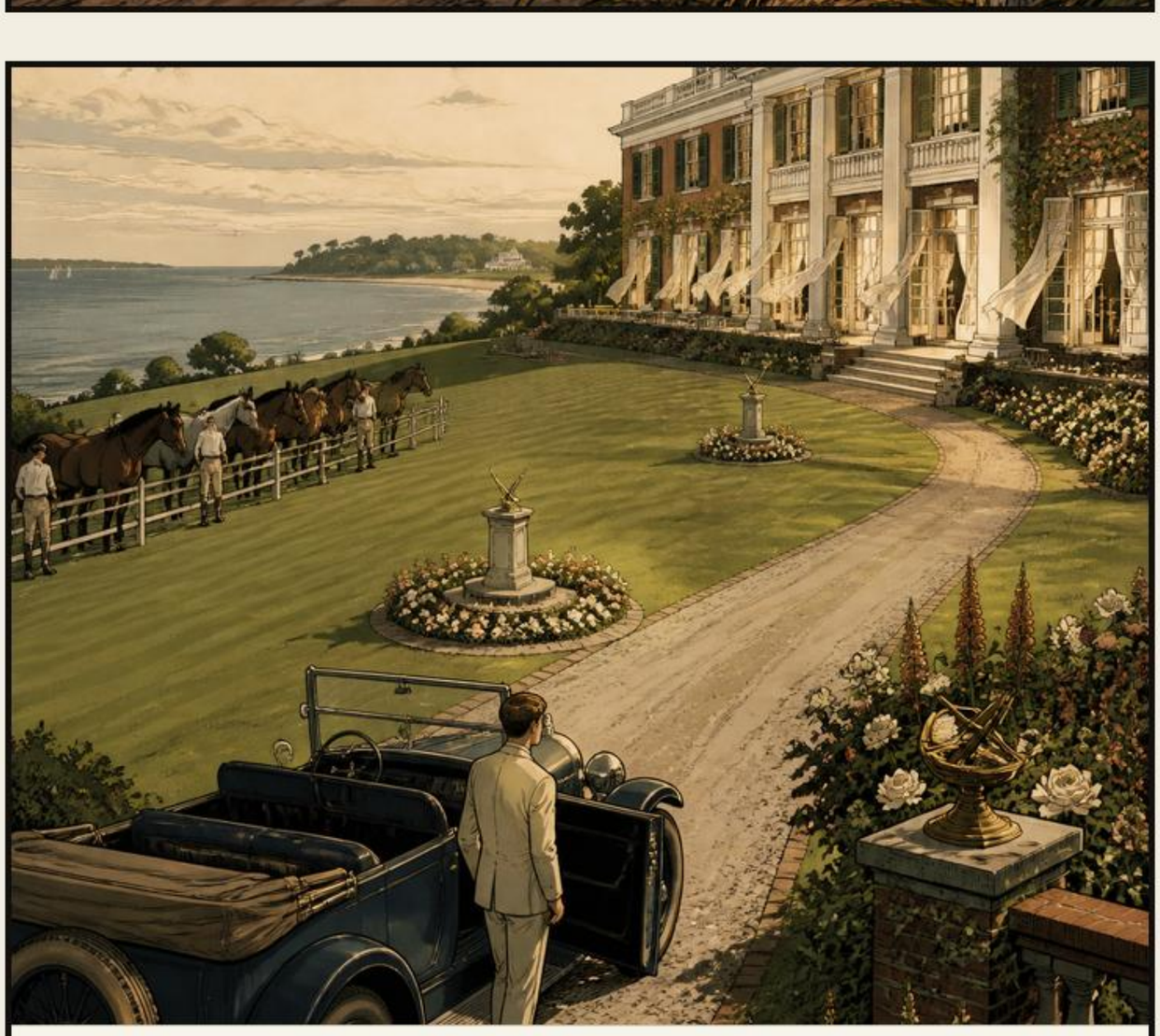


Across the courtesy bay the white palaces of fashionable East Egg glittered along the water — and the history of the summer really begins the evening I drove over there to dine with the Tom Buchanans.



Daisy was my second cousin once removed, and I'd known Tom in college. Just after the war I spent two days with them in Chicago.





Tom Buchanan in riding clothes stood with his legs apart on the front porch. He had changed since New Haven — a sturdy straw-haired man of thirty now, with a hard mouth, a supercilious manner, and two shining arrogant eyes that had established dominance over his face. Not even the effeminate swank of those riding clothes could hide the enormous power of that body — a cruel body — and his gruff husky tenor only added to the fractiousness he conveyed.

Tom had been one of the most powerful ends ever to play football at New Haven — a national figure at twenty-one, whose every later thing would savour of anticlimax. His family were enormously wealthy; now he'd come East in a way that rather took your breath away — he'd brought down a string of polo ponies from Lake Forest.



There was a touch of paternal contempt in his voice, even toward people he liked.



He walked me through a high hallway into a bright rosy space, fragilely bound into the house by French windows at either end.



A breeze blew the curtains like pale flags, and two young women in white floated on the couch as on an anchored balloon.



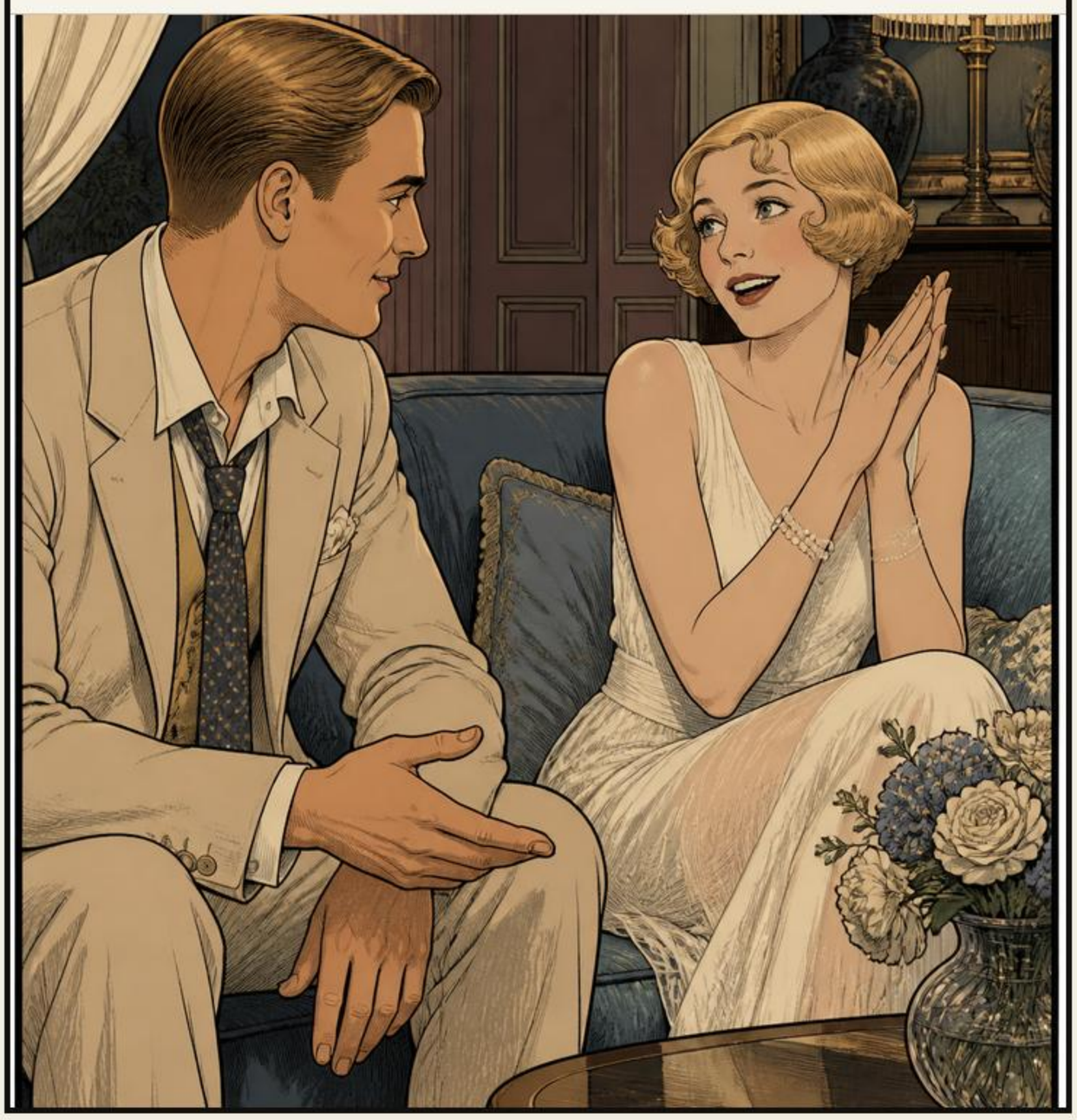


She murmured that the balancing girl's name was Baker — whose lips fluttered, who nodded almost imperceptibly, and tipped her head back again.

Her voice was the kind the ear follows up and down, an arrangement of notes never to be played again. I told her how a dozen friends in Chicago had sent their love.



I told her the whole town was desolate, that every car had its left rear wheel painted black as a mourning wreath.



Tom, who had been hovering restlessly, stopped and rested his hand on my shoulder, asking what I did.





Miss Baker's 'Absolutely!' came so suddenly I started. She unfolded into the room cadet-straight, waving off the cocktails, and I wondered what it was she 'got done.'

Her grey sun-strained eyes met mine. I felt I had seen her, or a picture of her, somewhere before.



Before I could answer, dinner was announced. Tom wedged my arm under his and moved me from the room like a checker to another square.



Why candles, Daisy objected, snuffing them with her fingers.



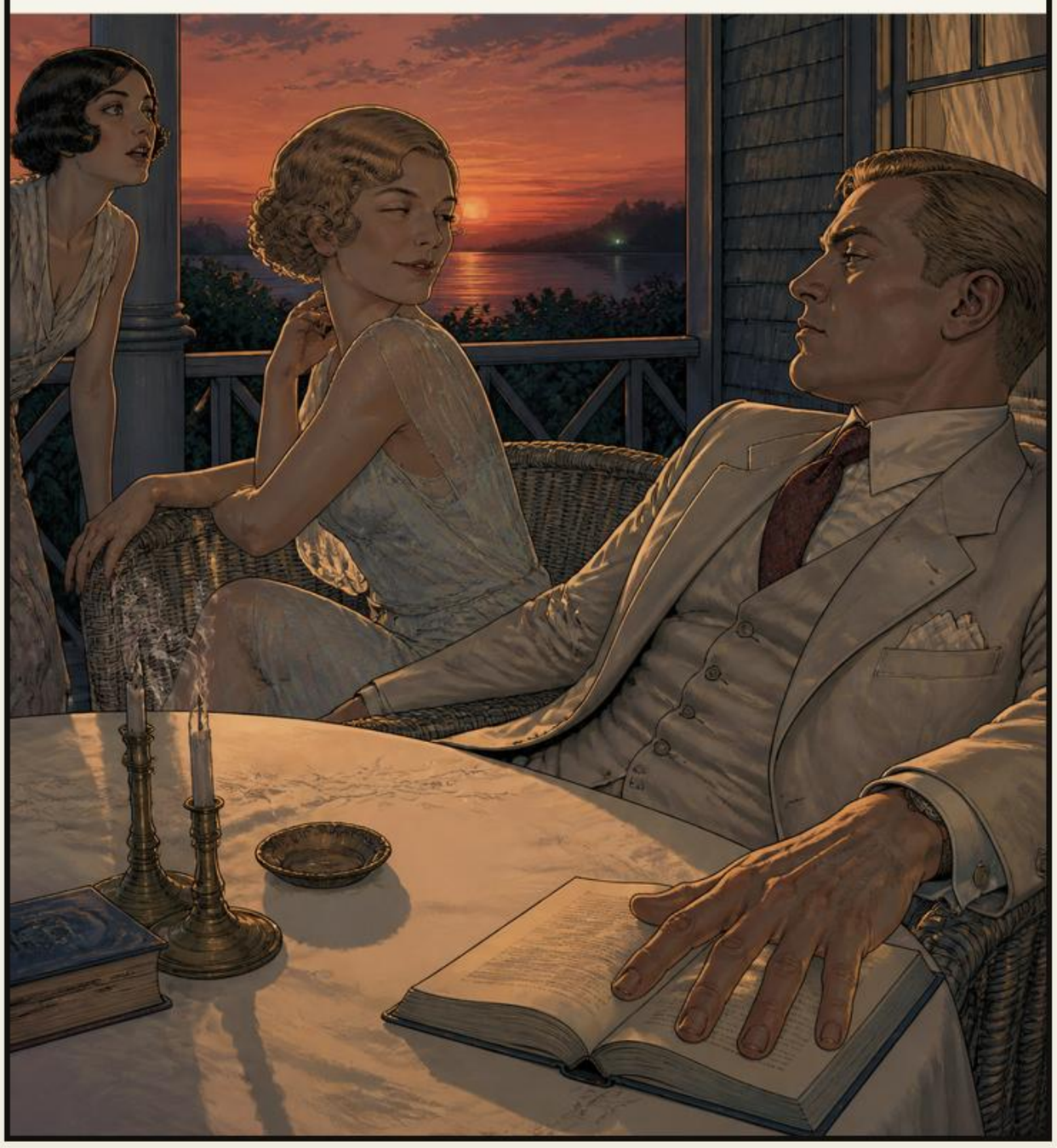
Her eyes fastened on her little finger. The knuckle was black and blue.



Tom had grown profound. He had a book, and he meant us to know it.



It was scientific, he said. Proved. The dominant race must watch out, or be submerged.



The telephone rang inside. The butler stepped away — but Tom frowned, pushed back his chair, and went after it without a word.





Before I had grasped her meaning, Tom and Daisy were back. "It couldn't be helped," Daisy cried, with tense gaiety — something about a nightingale on the lawn, come over on the Cunard or White Star Line.

The telephone rang inside, startlingly — and Daisy shook her head. The subject of the stables, in fact all subjects, vanished into air. Even Jordan could not quite put that fifth guest's shrill metallic urgency out of mind.



Tom and Miss Baker strolled back into the library, while, trying to look pleasantly interested and a little deaf, I followed Daisy around the verandas to the porch in front.



In the deep gloom we sat side by side. She took her face in her hands as if feeling its lovely shape, her eyes moving out into the velvet dusk. I asked some sedative questions about her little girl.





Evidently she had reason to be.

Everything was terrible, she said—the most advanced people thought so, and she knew. She had been everywhere, seen everything, done everything.





The instant her voice broke off, I felt the basic insincerity of what she had said—as if the whole evening had been a trick to exact some contributory emotion from me. Then she looked at me with an absolute smirk, as if asserting her membership in a rather distinguished secret society to which she and Tom belonged.

Inside, the crimson room bloomed with light. Tom and Miss Baker sat at either ends of the long couch, and she had been reading aloud from the Saturday Evening Post—murmurous, uninflected, a soothing tune. When we came in, she held us silent a moment with a lifted hand.



Ten o'clock—time, she said, for a good girl to go to bed. Daisy explained Jordan was playing at Westchester tomorrow. I knew her now: that pleasingly contemptuous face had looked out at me from rotogravures of the sporting life, attached to some critical, unpleasant story I had long forgotten. After she'd gone, Tom said, 'She's a nice girl.'

Come over often, Nick—I'll fling you together.

Good night! I haven't heard a word.



Back in the crimson library, Tom worried aloud about Jordan.



I asked quickly where Jordan was from, and Daisy began on Louisville before Tom cut in.



They came to the door with me, side by side in a cheerful square of light. I started the motor—and Daisy called.



Three people, Daisy insisted, so it must be true. I wasn't even vaguely engaged—gossip publishing the banns was one of the reasons I'd come East.



Already it was deep summer on roadhouse roofs and petrol-pumps in pools of light. I ran the car under its shed and sat a while on an abandoned grass roller in the yard. The wind had blown off, leaving a loud bright night, frogs full of life under the bellows of the earth.



The silhouette of a moving cat wavered across the moonlight, and turning to watch it I saw I was not alone — fifty feet away, a figure had emerged from the shadow of my neighbour's mansion, hands in his pockets, regarding the silver pepper of the stars.



Something in his leisurely movements and the secure position of his feet suggested it was Mr. Gatsby himself, come out to determine what share was his of our local heavens. I decided to call to him — Miss Baker had mentioned him at dinner, and that would do for an introduction. But I didn't. He stretched out his arms toward the dark water in a curious way, and far as I was, I could have sworn he was trembling.





Involuntarily I glanced seaward — and distinguished nothing except a single green light, minute and far away, that might have been the end of a dock. When I looked once more for Gatsby he had vanished, and I was alone again in the unquiet darkness.